Isidore Geoffroy Saint-Hilaire — *Histoire générale et particulière des anomalies de l'organisation chez l'homme et les animaux, ou Traité de tératologie* (1832–1837)

The Boneyard is a collection of works left unfinished, unpublished, or unread at their authors' deaths — dry bones in the valley, in Ezekiel's image. Each presentation tells the scholar's story, weighs what survives of his work, and states plainly what completing it would take, so that a book the world never received whole can be met at last. Each of them was one of one. There will never be another like him, and his light will not shine again except through the work he left behind.

A Boneyard dossier — researched and presented by Robert Tilford, Hays, Kansas. Filed 14 October 2026.

Disclosure: prepared with AI assistance — the six subject reviewers named in the index are AI agents, each desk-checked at this desk; all rulings and final decisions are the author's own.

Dedication

To Isidore Geoffroy Saint-Hilaire (1805–1861), the son who completed his father's programme and gave a whole discipline its name. Where Étienne Geoffroy Saint-Hilaire had entered the study of human monstrosities, Isidore gave separate observations a system, with a classification, with laws, and with an account of causes, so that later workers had a field to work in rather than a cabinet of curiosities. The field is still known by the name he gave it, while its founding treatise is still cited in French. This edition is dedicated to restoring the founder's own text to the discipline he founded.

The author's own terms

Isidore introduced the term teratology itself: the study of anomalies of organisation in man and the animals, what older language called monstrosities.

The story

A father begins a programme of study, and a son completes it. Isidore Geoffroy

Saint-Hilaire (1805–1861) was the son of Étienne Geoffroy Saint-Hilaire, whose own work is the subject of a separate dossier in this collection, and who was blinded by stroke in 1840. The son completed the father's programme.

The work at issue is the *Histoire générale et particulière des anomalies de l'organisation chez l'homme et les animaux, ou Traité de tératologie* — a general and particular history of the anomalies of organisation in man and the animals, or treatise on teratology — published in Paris by J.-B. Baillière between 1832 and 1837. Teratology is the study of anomalies of organisation, of what older language called monstrosities. Isidore founded a discipline and named it: he introduced the term teratology itself.

To found a discipline is more than to write a book about a subject. It is to give separate observations a system, with a classification, with laws, and with an account of causes, so that later workers have a field to work in rather than a cabinet of curiosities. That is what this treatise did. It also completes, in a direct family and scholarly sense, his father's Vol. 2, on human monstrosities, by systematising the field that volume had entered.

Yet English scholarship still cites the treatise in French. A discipline that English-speaking medicine and biology use by the name Isidore gave it rests on a founding text that this research did not find in English.

One point must be left exactly as the record leaves it. The main source for this dossier describes the treatise as 3 vols. 8vo with 20 plates. Britannica says 4 vols. The volume count is UNCHECKED and unresolved in this package. This edition does not choose between those accounts.

The work and what survives

The treatise was published between 1832 and 1837. Isidore died in 1861, so the work is in the public domain.

Its survival is verified in one specific place. The Biodiversity Heritage Library's Darwin's Library index lists this title, with vols. 1 and 3 held and page-level indexing. That listing is a real anchor for beginning work, although, as the unresolved volume count shows, it does not by itself settle how many volumes the complete treatise comprises.

Its English fortunes

No English edition found after research. English scholarship cites it in French.

Its English fortune is therefore the same as its scholarly position more generally: the field it founded is known by its name, its findings are taken up by later writers, and the founding text itself remains to be read, by most English readers, only through other people's summaries.

What completing it would take

This is a large undertaking, and its size cannot even be stated finally until the volume count is pinned down. The count is UNCHECKED: 3 vols. in the main source, and 4 in Britannica. Volume 1 alone, in reprint, runs to about 696–698 pages, and there is also an atlas to reckon with.

The realistic course is therefore Vol. 1 first. That volume contains the Prolégomènes, the introductory foundations, together with the classification and the laws and causes of monstrosity. It is the part that sets out the discipline as a discipline.

The remaining volumes are to be scoped only after the count is pinned. To promise more than Vol. 1 before that question is answered would be to promise a whole whose extent is not yet established, and this edition makes no such promise.

Sources

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